

# China Merchants Energy Shipping Co Ltd (601872.SS): APAC Consumer & Leisure Corp Day: Mgmt expect a better VLCC TCE in 2H26 vs. 1H26

APAC Consumer &amp; Leisure Corporate Day

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We hosted China Merchants Energy Shipping Co Ltd (601872.SS, Not Covered) at our APAC Consumer & Leisure Corporate Day on July 3<sup>rd</sup>, 2026. Generally, **mgmt expect 2H26 VLCC TCE should be better than 1H26 with a floor at US\$150k/day in 3Q26 even if China does not resume crude restocking, as Gulf countries are ramping up oil shipment** through the Strait of Hormuz, **and sees further upside from: i) China restocking, which mgmt believe could start in Aug at the latest; and ii) potential permanent lift of sanctions over Iranian oil which the company believes could add 5ppts demand to compliant fleet.** Other key takeaways include: 1) Mgmt expect supply shortage for VLCC to persist until at least til 2028, as the 200-vessel orderbook faces delivery uncertainties and is heavily offset by 266 aging vessels exceeding 20 years of age during 2026-28; 2) the dry bulk market is performing stronger than expected heading into peak 3Q-4Q, supporting freight rates above breakeven on robust iron ore, bauxite, and minor bulk shipments.

## Key Takeaways

- **VLCC TCE outlook:** Since the US and Iran signed a MoU on Jun 17<sup>th</sup>, VLCC TCE has rallied but peaked out on June 22<sup>nd</sup>, which mgmt attributes to weak China restocking demand, while mgmt still expect **the industry average VLCC TCE in 2H26 to be better than 1H26, as Gulf countries are ramping up oil shipment** through the Strait of Hormuz. Mgmt forecast the avg industry VLCC TCE **to reach US\$150k/day in 3Q26** considering the overall industry supply-demand has improved vs. Apr-May, before factoring in additional demand from China restocking/potential removal of sanctions on Iranian oil, and improved from US\$120k/100k per day in 2Q26/1Q26.
- **Restocking demand:** Mgmt believe the market is underestimating upside risks to VLCC TCE from rigid restocking demand. As currently the restocking demand is only from non-China countries, mgmt believe China may gradually resume refined fuel export quota, and expect SOE refiners to do restocking in

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July-August. That said, in the US, crude oil SPR has reduced by 89mn bbls to 326mn bbls as of Jun 26<sup>th</sup>, 2026 vs. Feb'26-end and the US gov targets to replenish SPR with at least 1.2 barrels by end of 2027 for each released, which mgmt expect to be a tailwind to TCE.

- **Scenario for removal of sanctions on Iranian oil:** Mgmt noted that a potential permanent removal of Iranian oil sanctions could act as a major structural upside catalyst for the compliant tanker market. Though a 60-day waiver for sanctions over Iranian oil is currently in place, mgmt observed that compliant fleets remain hesitant to participate in the Iranian oil trade, leaving the trade to shadow fleets. If sanctions on Iran oil are fully lifted, mgmt believe shifting Iranian oil seaborne volume to the compliant market could generate a 5pp in effective demand, which is in-line with our view (see Mar-26 report).
- **VLCC fleet development:** Mgmt expect supply shortage for VLCC to persist until at least 2028. Although the current VLCC orderbook stands at 200 vessels delivering in 2026-28 (see Jun-26 report), mgmt note actual delivery could be uncertain considering only 80-90% vessels were delivered on time based on last upcycle experience. Furthermore, supply addition could be heavily offset by an aging global fleet, with 266 vessels projected to exceed 20 years of age by the end of 2028, implying that net fleet growth will likely remain highly restricted.
- **Bulker outlook:** The dry bulk market is performing stronger-than-expected per mgmt heading into its peak 3Q-4Q, supporting freight rates above break-even. In major bulk, demand is being driven by 1) better-than-expected China demand for Iron Ore; 2) active iron ore shipments from Australia and Brazil; 3) urging bauxite exports from West Africa. Additionally, minor bulk shipments—including grain, steel, and fertilizers—continue to outperform expectations per mgmt, keeping the small-vessel market highly active.



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